

Chelonoidis elephantopus

Galapagos tortoise



Length	Up to 4 ft (1.2 m)
Breeding	Oviparous
Habit	Terrestrial
Status	Vulnerable

Location Galapagos Islands



The Galapagos tortoise, the largest living tortoise, has a huge carapace, massive limbs, and a long neck. The overall size and shell shape can vary depending on which of the Galapagos Islands the tortoise originates from. They spend most of their time grazing in small herds and basking in pools. During the breeding season, males become territorial and look for mates, while females create nests in the ground to lay their eggs. Despite some individuals living well over 100 years, this species remains vulnerable. The main threat is depredation by introduced species such as black rats and cats, as well as competition with cattle for food. The scientific name *Chelonoidis elephantopus* is widely used, but this is not without controversy. Some authorities have argued that the Galapagos tortoise should be viewed as up to 15 separate species and others claim that *C. nigra* is the correct name.

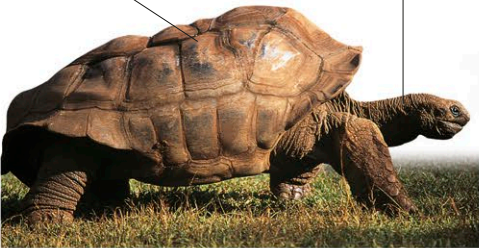


GENERALIZED HERBIVORE

The Galapagos tortoise has strong, toothless jaws well adapted to feeding on whatever type of vegetation it can find, including tough cacti.

saddle-backed shell allows greater neck movement

long neck can stretch up to shrubs and bushes

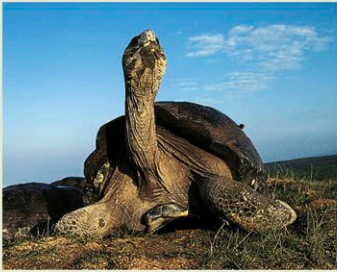


SHELL SHAPE

The shell of the Galapagos tortoise varies and is linked to feeding habit. A domed shell is common for subspecies that graze on grasses, whereas a saddle-backed shell is adapted for browsing shrubs.

CONSERVATION

Since 1965, the Charles Darwin Research Station has been running a breeding and repatriation program to boost the dwindling population of Galapagos tortoises. By 2016, the program had released 4,000 tortoises.



UNMISTAKABLE GIANT

The impressive size of the Galapagos tortoise is probably due to its adaptation to living in a difficult environment with an unreliable food supply—the larger the tortoise, the more nourishment it can store.